

Repatterning the Missing Experience - Part 2

with Mariah Rooney and Kai Cheng Thom

AGENDA

Reframing “Regulation”

Pleasure/Joy

Oppression/Collective Trauma

Working with Touch

Working with Polarities

Demonstration

Q & A



REFRAMING “REGULATION”

DECOLONIZING OUR UNDERSTANDING OF REGULATION

- Contemporary and popular understandings of “somatics” tends to place a high emphasis on “emotion regulation” and “nervous system regulation” - this is even common parlance in certain social circles
- What *is* nervous system regulation? What do we mean by it?
 - The ability to “control our emotions?”
 - The ability to reduce heightened sensation at will?
 - The ability to “calm down” when upset or “activated”?
 - The ability to feel a great deal of affect while remaining connected to a coherent sense of self and other?
 - What makes any of the above states “better” than dysregulation? **Discuss**



PLEASURE + JOY

Working With Pleasure & Joy

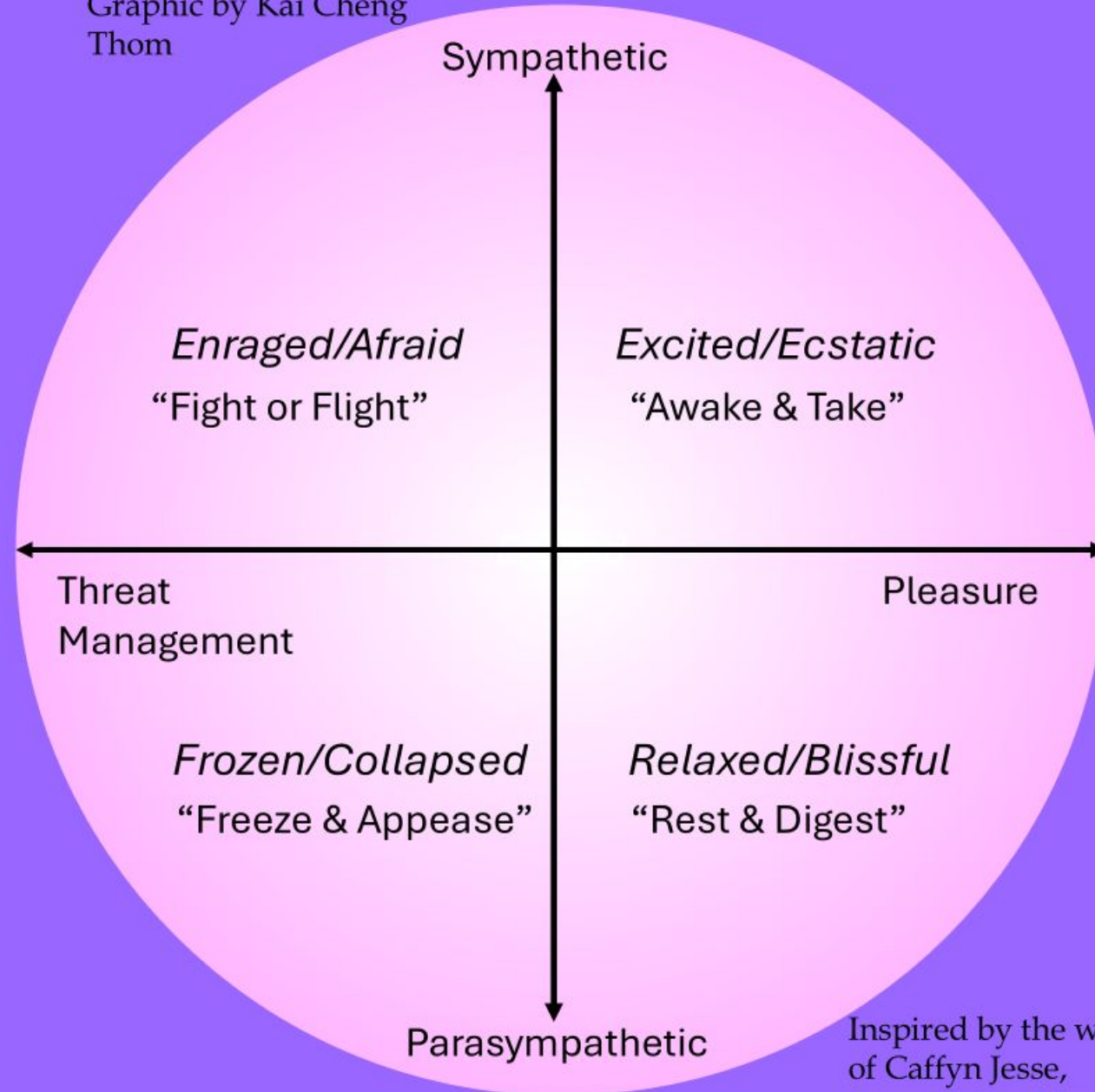
- Trauma healing work can also be reframed as “somatic whole-ing” working filling in the missing experiences, creating opportunities for what should have happened to happen
- Working with pain is not separate from working with pleasure; working with pleasure is not separate from working with pain
- This can be simple - usually the rituals of embodied healing and joy are embedded within the cultural knowledge of our own people's traditions
 - However, these traditional wisdoms are often oppressed or repressed within the dominant culture; ie Indigenous ceremony in North America, queer ballroom culture, Black musical traditions

The background of the slide is a solid brown color. It is decorated with white, hand-drawn style wavy lines. One line starts in the top right corner and curves downwards. Another line starts in the bottom left corner and curves upwards. A third line starts in the bottom right corner and curves upwards. These lines create a sense of movement and depth.

OPPRESSION + COLLECTIVE TRAUMA

Nervous System States, Survival & Pleasure

Graphic by Kai Cheng
Thom



Inspired by the work
of Caffyn Jesse,
Somatic Sex Educator

The Healing Spiral

by Kai Cheng Thom

Pleasure

Pain

8. Reconnecting
to life

7. Facing
Fears/Doing
the Impossible

6. Embracing
the Shadow

9. Sharing the medicine

2. Stabilization &
Grounding

10. The next
adventure

3. Exploration &
Self-Discovery

4. Descent into
the underworld

1. Initial Injury &
Spiritual Crisis

5. Collapse &
Transformation



**Rediscovery
of sacredness
in land,
Nature, Spirit**

**Felt sense of
empowered
choice
& voice**

**Ability to
integrate
multiple
truths**

**Embodied
Healing &
Whole-ing
Model**

Kai Cheng Thom

**Deepened
connection to
beloved
others**

**Reconnection
to pleasure &
joy**

**Expanded
capacity for
intense
sensation**



WORKING WITH TOUCH



TOUCH: FRAMING, COMPETENCIES & PRACTITIONER DEVELOPMENT

- **Start with your own work**
 - Touch is only as attuned and ethical as the practitioner offering it...ongoing personal work helps clarify intention, boundaries, countertransference, and impact
- **Receive touch-based work yourself**
 - Experiencing touch in your own nervous system builds somatic literacy, helps you track subtle activation/deactivation, and teaches you what skillful, trauma-informed touch feels like
- **Understand the therapeutic rationale**
 - Touch must be grounded in a clear clinical intention...supporting regulation, orienting, boundary repair, or attachment needs...not used to soothe the therapist's discomfort or fill relational gaps
- **Know your scope and limitations**
 - Learn what types of touch fall safely within your practice, when to refer to bodyworkers, and how state laws, licensure, and supervision shape your scope
- **Develop attunement and somatic tracking skills**
 - Attuned touch requires the ability to track breath, micro-movements, bracing, dissociation, impulse, and shifts in state

TOUCH: FRAMING, COMPETENCIES & PRACTITIONER DEVELOPMENT

- **Consent and collaborative process**
 - Build skill in verbal consent, ongoing check-ins, nonverbal cues of “yes/no,/maybe” and the capacity to repair when a client’s system signals overwhelm or withdrawal
- **Recognize trauma and cultural histories of touch**
 - Clients carry personal, ancestral, and cultural experiences that shape how touch is perceived/experienced. We must assess for safety, meaning, and potential harm
- **Learn a range of touch skills**
 - Practices may include grounding touch, containment, resourcing touch, boundary-supported touch, and supportive contact for orienting or co-regulation
- **Practice pacing and titration**
 - Skillful touch work moves slowly, tracks impact moment-by-moment, and respects the client’s pace, capacity, and readiness
- **Humility and ongoing mentorship/guidance/supervision/consultation**
 - Touch work requires continuous supervision, peer consultation, advanced training, and a willingness to be an ongoing learner/student



WORKING WITH POLARITIES

ENGAGING POLARITIES + FRAGMENTED PARTS

- Somatically accessing internal incongruence/conflict
 - Parts can hold contradictory needs/urges/patterning such as push/pull, proximity/distance, collapse/activation
 - Somatically contacting these polarities can allow for both direct and indirect contact without having to find coherence in narrative (a step in the process)
 - Over time, tracking the body and interoceptive awareness supports more differentiation and discernment of different part's needs, procedural learning, strategies, adaptations, etc.
 - The goal isn't always to re/solve the polarity, but to work towards more cohesion and collaboration



DEMONSTRATION

The background of the slide is a solid brown color. It is decorated with white, hand-drawn style wavy lines. One line is in the top right corner, and another, longer line is in the bottom left corner.

QUESTIONS

The background of the slide is a solid brown color. It is decorated with white, hand-drawn style wavy lines. One line starts in the top right corner and curves downwards. Another line starts in the bottom left corner and curves upwards. A third line starts in the bottom right corner and curves upwards. These lines create a sense of movement and organic form.

THANK YOU